

FROM CAPTURE TO CARE

Initiating Responsible Web Archiving at NIOD

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Abstract – Web archiving has become increasingly important for documenting contemporary conflicts and mass violence. However, heritage institutions face significant challenges when deciding what and how to collect from dynamic digital environments. This paper examines web archiving practices at the NIOD Institute for War, Holocaust and Genocide Studies, whose primary focus previously has been on collecting analogue materials. Through a qualitative case study combining institutional analysis and conceptual modeling, we identify the following key tensions shaping web archiving decisions: abundance and selection, visibility and vulnerability, speed and care, and, privacy and transparency. To explore these tensions, we introduce a decision simulator that models how archival values – ethics, sustainability, legality, transparency, and completeness – interact through institutional choices. We argue that web archiving should be understood as an ongoing institutional process shaped by cumulative decisions rather than a purely technical task, and we propose the simulator as a conceptual tool for reflecting on the trade-offs involved in building web archives.

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I. INTRODUCTION

The NIOD Institute for War, Holocaust and Genocide Studies has a long-standing tradition of research and collection-building with the Second World War as its central focal point. Even though war and genocide studies encompass a wide range of topics, such as contemporary armed conflicts, ongoing instances of mass violence, and modern

manifestations of genocide, these remain underrepresented in NIOD's collection. Because these conflicts are increasingly documented in digital environments, a strategy put forward by the NIOD to tackle this problem is web archiving.

By systematically capturing online sources, web archiving enables institutions to document contemporary events in real time and to preserve a wide range of perspectives on selected topics. However, establishing web archiving practices requires institutions to make a series of complex decisions regarding scope, collection strategies, access, and long-term stewardship.

This paper examines the emergence of web archiving initiatives at NIOD and analyzes the institutional tensions that shape these decisions. To investigate these dynamics, we developed an interactive web archiving decision simulator, *Making the Archive*, which models the trade-offs involved in building web archives. We argue that such tools can support institutions in approaching web archiving as an ongoing process of institutional judgement rather than solely a technical undertaking.

II. METHODOLOGY

For this study, we adopted a qualitative, multi-method research design to examine how web archiving reshapes archival responsibility in the context of the NIOD. This approach combines conceptual analysis, empirical inquiry through interviews, and scenario-based exploration in order to foreground decision-making and trade-offs involved in initiating web archiving practices.

1. Initially, we conducted a literature review focused on archival theory and web archiving scholarship. This review informed the conceptual framing of the project, particularly around archival selection, digital abundance and ephemerality, ethics of care, transparency, and governance. The literature was used analytically to identify recurring challenges and concepts, which subsequently structured the empirical and design-based components of the research.
2. Our group performed a stakeholder and tension mapping exercise which did not aim to produce a fixed stakeholder model, but rather to identify relationships, hierarchies, and problem areas shaping web archiving at NIOD. The mapping helped clarify how institutional mandates, legal frameworks, technical infrastructures, creators, and users intersect; and where conflicts between values such as completeness, sustainability, legality, and care arise.
3. Using a semi-structured approach, we conducted interviews with staff members from NIOD's collections and digital documentation department. We structured the interview questions around current practices, institutional constraints, emerging discussions around web-based materials, and considerations related to selection, transparency, ethics, and sustainability. These interviews provided insight into how theoretical concerns identified in the literature manifest in institutional practice, and helped ground our project in NIOD's specific context.
4. Our project adopts a scenario-based, designed research component in the form of an interactive decision simulator. The simulator translates insights from the literature review, stakeholder mapping, and interviews into a structured decision model involving institutional choices related to scope, collection methods, access, and documentation. Rather than functioning as a predictive or solution-oriented tool, the simulator operates as an analytical device for exploring how archival values are negotiated over time and how consequences come up through cumulative decisions.

These methods allow the project to move between theory, institutional practice, and exploratory design. By combining empirical case study work with an experimental modeling tool, we seek to make visible how responsibility, constraint, and judgement are produced through institutional processes. This methodological approach reinforces an understanding of web archiving as an ongoing practice shaped by cumulative decisions rather than isolated choices; providing the foundation for the analysis of NIOD's current position and the implications of initiating web archiving practices.

III. CASE STUDY

"The stakes are high. If we do not come to grasps with web archives, the histories we will write will be fundamentally flawed" [1]. Against this backdrop, Ian Milligan's urgency to shed light on what gets lost if institutions look past the web, highlights the need to examine the gaps in current archival practices at NIOD. Although the institute has historically focused on the Second World War, its mandate has gradually expanded toward a broader, comparative engagement with mass violence in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

NIOD itself emphasizes that recurring research themes include: "perpetratorship, memories, and trauma, transitional justice, restoration of rights, regime changes and behaviour and experiences;" reflecting an ambition to study mass violence in a multidisciplinary and international framework [2]. This expansion in research scope has historically been accompanied by active collecting practices. From its early years, NIOD staff have not only received personal documents such as diaries, correspondence, and photo albums, but have also actively searched for relevant material themselves.

At the same time, NIOD is institutionally embedded within a broader governance framework. As a research institute under the Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts and Sciences (KNAW), and indirectly funded by the Ministry of Education, Culture and Science (OCW), NIOD operates within cultural policy frameworks that highlight accessibility, plurality, quality, and public accountability. Initiatives such as the *Netwerk Digitaal Erfgoed*, supported by OCW, further signal an expectation that heritage institutions should engage in digital collaboration and interoperability [3]. This institutional positioning creates both opportunities and constraints for web archiving. While NIOD has strong research legitimacy and access to digital preservation infrastructures

through KNAW, its role as a publicly funded memory institution also heightens legal, ethical, and governance responsibilities when engaging with contemporary, web-based material.

IV. KEY TENSIONS

Web archiving at NIOD is structured by a set of recurring tensions that structure how decisions about scope, selection, access, and documentation are negotiated in practice. These tensions persist across different stages of the archival process and accumulate over time.

The first tension emerges between abundance and selection. Digital environments produce an overwhelming volume of web-based material related to contemporary conflicts, creating expectations of comprehensive documentation. At the same time, digital abundance does not eliminate the need for selection; rather, it intensifies it [4]. Similarly, institutional mandates, research relevance, and long-term stewardship impose limits on what can be responsibly preserved. Thus, selection, as opposed to being a failure of capacity becomes an inherent condition of web archiving.

Another point of tension also concerns visibility and vulnerability. Web archiving increases the visibility of individuals, communities, and narratives that may otherwise remain undocumented, particularly in relation to conflict, displacement, and trauma. Visibility, therefore, cannot be treated as an unqualified good but must be weighed against the vulnerability of those represented in web-based records.

The tension between speed and care comes up specifically when considering accessibility. Contemporary conflicts unfold rapidly online, generating pressure to collect material in near real-time before it disappears [4]. However, ethical reflection, legal assessment, and contextualization require time. While it may be technically possible to collect quickly, responsible documentation demands careful deliberation, particularly when dealing with sensitive material. This creates a structural tension between timely intervention and ethical restraint, in which acting too slowly risks loss, while acting too quickly risks harm.

Lastly, a persistent tension exists between privacy and transparency. Transparency is widely recognized within NIOD as essential for accountability, research integrity, and public trust. Documenting selection criteria, search terms, and methodological choices enables critical engagement

with archival collections [5]. Concurrently, legal and privacy obstacles limit what can be disclosed about both the contents of collections and the individuals represented within them. Transparency, in this sense, does not eliminate ethical risk but operates as a form of accountability that must coexist with necessary restrictions.

These tensions do not function independently. Decisions made to address one tension often intensify another; increasing the selectivity may reduce visibility, prioritizing speed may undermine care, and expanding transparency may conflict with privacy protections. Rather than resolving these tensions, they should be understood as constitutive elements of web archiving practice. In this study they provide the analytical basis for the decision simulator, where archival choices are modeled not as right or wrong solutions, but as trade-offs whose consequences emerge cumulatively over time.

V. ANALYSIS

The preceding sections show that web archiving at NIOD is structured by persistent tensions and negotiated responsibilities. In this section, our analysis examines how these tensions translate into concrete institutional decision-making. Drawing on insights from the case study and interviews, and situating them within existing web archiving scholarship, we examine how these tensions emerge within existing institutional discussions and how they may be negotiated as these practices develop further. While our analysis is grounded in the NIOD case study, the dynamics described here reflect broader challenges faced by heritage institutions seeking to develop web archiving strategies.

Scope and Collection Strategies

At NIOD, decisions about scope illustrate how the tension between abundance and selection becomes operational in institutional practice. Digital environments produce vast quantities of material related to contemporary conflicts, yet institutional mandates, research value, legal obligations, and long-term preservation considerations limit what can be responsibly collected. Comprehensive capture is therefore neither feasible nor desirable, requiring archivists to develop selection strategies that balance documentation with sustainability.

One approach frequently discussed in relation to NIOD's collecting logic is the use of hotspots [5;6]. This approach focuses on collection efforts of

identifiable events or themes, making selection criteria explicit while avoiding claims of exhaustive coverage. In Dutch archival practice, hotspots refer to events that generate significant societal attention, controversy, or political debate, and are therefore considered particularly relevant for documentation and preservation [7;8]. However, thematic collection strategies also introduce structural limitations. By privileging identifiable events and highly visible platforms, they risk reproducing existing media hierarchies, constraining ethical reflections, and stabilizing present-day institutional framings as future archival structures [9]. Decisions about scope, therefore, involve balancing the need for pragmatic selection mechanisms with the risk that these mechanisms shape how future histories are constructed. This dynamic illustrates how early scoping decisions influence the range of possible archival outcomes that emerge later in the archival process.

Scope decisions also intersect with the tension between visibility and vulnerability. Web archiving can increase the visibility of communities, actors, and narratives that might otherwise remain undocumented. Simultaneously, documenting online traces related to conflict, displacement, or trauma may expose individuals to unwanted scrutiny or misinterpretation in the future. Decisions about which platforms and sources to include requires institutions to balance the archival value of increased visibility with the ethical responsibility to protect vulnerable subjects.

Collection strategies operationalize scope through specific tools and workflows. Automated approaches such as crawling and keyword harvesting offer scalability and consistency, but they also relocate curatorial decisions into technical parameters such as seed lists, keyword sets, and crawl depth [9]. Similarly, scale does not remove appraisal, but relocates structural choices that shape what can later be studied [4]. Manual curation, by contrast, allows contextual sensitivity and case-specific judgement, but increases labor demands and risks narrowing selection to what is visible to staff at a given moment. Hybrid approaches attempt to balance these models, but introduce new governance questions concerning how responsibilities are distributed between automated systems and human judgement [5].

Algorithms further complicate this dynamic. Collection tools determine not only what is captured and what is missed, but search interfaces and

discovery systems also influence what users are able to encounter in web archives. As the opacity of algorithmic systems is central to digital infrastructures, tool-level decisions should be understood as part of archival appraisal rather than neutral technical processes [4].

The deliberations over collection tools also reflect the tension between speed and care in web archiving. Digital traces related to contemporary conflicts may disappear quickly, creating pressure for rapid capture. However, careful appraisal, contextualization, and ethical reflection require time. Automated approaches allow institutions to respond quickly to volatile online environments, but they may reduce opportunities for deliberation about the ethical implications of collecting sensitive material.

Documentation and Metadata

If scope and collection strategies determine what enters the archive, documentation determines how those decisions remain intelligible over time. As NIOD considers the development of web archiving practices, documentation becomes a central mechanism for addressing the tension between transparency and privacy.

Transparency in this context does not refer to claims of neutrality but to the systematic recording of what was done and why [5;6]. For this reason, metadata plays a crucial role in making institutional decision-making visible. Descriptive, technical, and administrative metadata collectively determine whether an archived collection remains interpretable in the future. Recording parameters such as crawl frequency, seed URLs, depth, time boundaries, and selection rationales frame what future users can infer about what was captured, what may be missing, and why certain choices were made.

This connects directly to a literacy problem identified by Schafer and Winters (2021) in web archives: accessing archived material requires not only technical access, but also an understanding of how these collections were produced. In this sense, metadata is not auxiliary to web archives, but part of the interpretive apparatus that makes web archives usable as historical evidence [10].

One method that may support this form of accountable transparency is the use of data envelopes [5]. Data envelopes provide a way to document the existence, scope, provenance, and access restrictions of collected material without exposing content that could cause harm or violate

legal limitations [11]. This is especially relevant in web archives of conflict, where record subjects may not anticipate long-term preservation or future reuse of their digital traces.

Data envelopes also sharpen the role of metadata as governance. They enable institutions to communicate what exists, under what conditions it was collected, what limitations apply – such as copyright, privacy, platform restrictions – and what access pathways exist. In this way, they help reconcile the preservation of content with the documentation of contextual constraints. However, transparency through documentation does not eliminate ethical risk or structural bias, nor does it resolve tensions around exclusion or power. Instead, data envelopes function as a form of accountable disclosure, enabling critical interpretation without guaranteeing ethical outcomes.

Access, Collaboration, and Sustainability

Questions of access reveal how the tensions identified earlier extend beyond collection practices to the long-term governance of web archives. Making archived materials accessible increases institutional responsibility, particularly when collections contain personal data or sensitive material related to ongoing conflicts. Different access regimes – such as open access, request-based systems, on-site consultation, or delayed release – distribute risk and responsibility differently. Access also connects to collaboration and infrastructure. The emergence of “sharing zones,” where institutions exchange metadata or derivative datasets to support cross-institutional research infrastructures, speaks to this development. Within the Dutch digital heritage landscape, such approaches may allow NIOD to collaborate with other memory institutions while maintaining its own curatorial framing and ethical restrictions. In this respect, sharing zones illustrate how the tension between transparency and privacy extends beyond individual collections to the governance of digital heritage infrastructures. These arrangements allow institutions to share technical resources while maintaining curatorial control over how collections are contextualized and accessed.

On the other hand, participation in such infrastructures also introduces new constraints. Institutional decision-making becomes embedded within wider governance frameworks, technical standards, and resource allocations that extend beyond the control of any single organization. This highlights the central role of sustainability, which

functions as both a practical and ethical condition shaping web archiving strategies. Contrary to assumptions that digital storage is unlimited, long-term preservation requires ongoing maintenance, infrastructure, and institutional commitment. Thus, selection emerges not as a limitation but as a responsible strategy for managing long-term archival obligations.

Together, these dynamics illustrate how web archiving decisions unfold through interconnected choices about scope, documentation, access, and sustainability. Instead of producing a single optimal strategy, these decisions accumulate over time and generate the institutional outcomes discussed in the following section.

VI. SIMULATOR

To explore how the aforementioned tensions translate into institutional decision-making, we developed an interactive simulation tool titled: *Making the Archive: A Web Archiving Decision Simulator*. The tool was designed to model how different institutional priorities can lead to divergent archival outcomes.

The design is informed by the literature review, interviews, and stakeholder mapping exercises we conducted during the case study, which helped identify decision points that institutions encounter when developing their web archiving practices. These decision points were mapped onto four sequential dilemmas. Each dilemma offers two possible choices, with each decision influencing a set of archival values, thereby generating outcomes that illustrate how different institutional priorities influence what sort of collection is ultimately created.

The decision points remain constant across each pathway. The first dilemma is concerned with setting the scope in terms of what will be collected in the web archive. Users decide between aligning with prevailing institutional guidelines of gathering news media, or branching out and gathering sources from social media as well. This choice reflects the challenges that institutions face when, on the one hand, seeking to be ambitious in their methodology and introduce representational diversity, while, on the other hand, also being able to sustainably manage their archival environment.

Afterwards, users are faced with how they wish to collect the resources within that specified scope. This second dilemma navigates between privileging

automated technologies and human-led collection strategies. While automated web crawling might offer cost-effective and comprehensive capture, they may be less adaptable to version changes and are confronted with the opacity of black-box algorithms. Meanwhile, the human-led approach means getting to grips with new workflows and navigating blind spots, while providing more curatorial selectivity and adaptability.

The third dilemma focuses on collection expansion. Here, the user is faced with the choice to either help build inter-organizational heritage infrastructures through linked open data or further contextualize their collection through community engagement initiatives, such as interviews and workshops. This decision node thereby explores what forms of knowledge production are privileged when expanding the archival infrastructure.

Finally, players arrive at the conclusive dilemma, which explores two different access regimes for the web archive. There is the choice to make the collection freely available online, or to make it accessible through a request system, in which users motivate their reasons for consultation.

Each decision is tied to a scoring system that operationalizes five institutional values, namely: ethics, sustainability, legality, transparency, and completeness. Making decisions therefore influences how the collection and institution are positioned in relation to these value dimensions. In this way, the player is directly confronted with the tradeoffs that different decisions consist of, and how these lead to divergent archival outcomes. The outcomes are consequently visualized in sixteen spider graphs that model which institutional priorities were emphasized during each playthrough.

The simulator thereby translates abstract debates about web archiving into concrete scenarios that allow institutions to reflect on how different priorities shape the archives they aim to produce. The simulator nevertheless has its limitations. For instance, there are many dilemmas left to explore, and existing dilemmas could be expanded through an expansion of available choices, such as a hybrid collection strategy. Additionally, the current model does not simulate interdependencies between different choices, for example, how a broad scope may constrain accessibility choices due to copyright and ethical concerns. Furthermore, the value system is heavily dependent on our interpretation of web archiving literature as well as our practical

understanding drawn only from one institutional case study site.

As a consequence, we elected to include a set of reflexive questions at each end scenario, where we explicitly ask for feedback on the tool and on unexplored strategies. We hope that by making the files freely available on GitHub, interested parties will be inspired to further develop the simulator to suit their needs.

Ultimately, our aim was to design a reflective tool that supports institutional discussions around their web archiving strategy. The simulator was presented at the NIOD, where a group of employees could argue their preferred choices before collectively making final decisions. In this way, it externalized decision-making into an interactive format, which provided a shared language through which different perspectives and priorities could be articulated more clearly. Used in internal meetings or workshop settings, the simulator may thus help other heritage institutions reduce uncertainty in strategic discussions by translating abstract tensions into a structured set of choices and outcomes.

VII. IMPLICATIONS & OUTCOMES

Our analysis demonstrates that web archiving at NIOD cannot be resolved through a stable policy framework. Instead, it produces a set of institutional implications that concern how responsibility is distributed over time, how decisions accumulate, and how archival practice is made accountable under conditions of uncertainty. The outcomes of our project therefore do not take the form of definitive solutions, but rather of clarified consequences and procedural insights that can guide responsible institutional action. Five key implications emerge from our findings.

First, archival responsibility is not established or undermined by a singular decision, but is built up through a sequence of choices made throughout the archival process. Choices made early in the process – such as defining hotspots, selecting capture tools, or delegating appraisal to automated systems – shape the range of options available later. Thus, no single decision is catastrophic in itself; ethical risk, sustainability pressure, and representational bias arise through the accumulation of decisions across the archival continuum. This insight directly informed the design of the simulator, where consequences become visible only through extended decision paths.

Second, completeness, ethical care, sustainability, legality, and transparency operate in tension rather than in harmony; as a result, they cannot be maximized simultaneously. Expanding coverage may constrain documentation and contextualization, increasing transparency may conflict with legal obligations, and prioritizing sustainability through technology may result in rapid capture but may also undermine ethical deliberation.

These tensions should not be interpreted as institutional failure, but as structural limits inherent to web archiving under conditions of digital abundance and ephemerality. Recognizing these limits enables NIOD to frame selectivity as responsible judgement rather than as a deficiency.

Third, documentation becomes a critical mechanism of accountability, not a guarantee of neutrality. Practices such as metadata enrichment, procedural documentation, and the use of the data-envelopes do not eliminate bias, harm, or exclusion. However, they enable institutions to explain how and why decisions were made, and to render absences and constraints legible for future users. Discussions with NIOD staff further indicated that documentation of earlier analog collection practices is often limited, complicating later interpretation and accountability [5;6]. As the use of technical systems and algorithms increases 'black box' opacity in digital environments [1], transparency in this sense functions as a form of institutional self-positioning that allows archives to acknowledge intervention without claiming objectivity or exhaustiveness.

Fourth, web archiving shifts NIOD's institutional role from a primarily retrospective archive to an active participant in contemporary knowledge production. Although the institute has long practiced selective collecting for its Second World War collections, documenting contemporary conflicts requires a more proactive approach to identifying and capturing material. By intervening in live digital environments, NIOD increasingly participates in shaping how present-day conflicts may be studied, remembered, and interpreted in the future by researchers and broader publics. This transition heightens ethical and governance responsibilities, particularly in relation to affected communities whose digital traces may be preserved without their anticipation of archival reuse.

Finally, ethical intent is constrained by infrastructure and resources. Even well-motivated archival decisions are molded by legal frameworks,

technical systems, staffing capacity, and external dependencies. Recognizing these obstacles does not resolve responsibility, but situates ethical care within the realities of institutional practice. Drawing on the concept of radical empathy in archival work [12], ethical care in web archiving may therefore reside not in comprehensive preservation, but in the recognition of relational obligations toward record subjects, communities, and future users. From this perspective, ethical care is exercised through conscious decisions about what should not be made visible or accessible.

Ultimately, these outcomes support an approach that prioritizes process over prescription. Instead of proposing a fixed web archiving strategy, our project offers NIOD a framework for initiating web archiving as a reflective, documented, and sustainable institutional practice – one that acknowledges trade-offs, renders decision-making visible, and treats responsibility as an ongoing commitment rather than a resolved problem.

VIII. CONCLUSION

The NIOD case study on web archiving led us to think beyond the implementation of technical tools. Instead, it involves a broader reconfiguration of institutional practices, responsibilities and priorities. Decisions about scope, collection methods, documentation and access are shaped by legal frameworks, infrastructural dependencies, ethical considerations and long-term sustainability concerns.

This study focused on one specific institution, but the identified tensions are not unique to NIOD in particular. Documenting contemporary events that unfold rapidly within ever-changing digital environments, requires adaptive and reflexive methods that many traditional heritage institutions will need to develop. Questions of selection, transparency, sustainability and responsibility therefore extend beyond institutional boundaries, and are inherent to the conditions of web archiving as a whole.

The decision simulator presented in this paper was developed as a way of making these tensions visible. By modeling institutional decision pathways and their consequences, the tool provides a structured, playful environment through which heritage institutions can reflect on the trade-offs that shape web archiving strategies. While the simulator simplifies the complexity of real-world archival

praxis, it offers a starting point for internal discussions.

Ultimately, approaching web archiving as a process of cumulative, institutional decision-making may help organizations develop more transparent, reflexive, and sustainable strategies for documenting the digital past and present.

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EXTERNAL LINKS

Link to the GitHub: <https://github.com/jorannathoe/Case-Study-AIS-JLL-2026-Decision-Game>.

Link to the simulator: <https://jorannathoe.github.io/Case-Study-AIS-JLL-2026-Decision-Game/>.